

Syllabus Design

Introduction

In ESP, a syllabus is an essential part of course design. Designing an effective ESP syllabus begins with understanding learners' needs. Based on this analysis, teachers select relevant language, skills, and tasks that will help students perform effectively in real-life contexts. There are different types of syllabi used in ESP such as skill-based, task-based, content-based and functional syllabi.

1. Definition

Syllabus design is a critical aspect of educational planning. It refers to the process of developing a structured course of learning. It includes selecting and organizing course content, learning outcomes, materials, teaching methods, and evaluation processes to meet the educational objectives of a particular course. The syllabus design typically involves a series of steps to create an effective and coherent educational program.

A syllabus serves as a comprehensive guide for both teachers and students alike. It functions as a blueprint, outlining the content and methodology of a particular course of study. Before creating a new syllabus, the designer must first reflect upon a series of crucial questions and prerequisites that must be taken into account, including students, their number, previous educational background, and their anticipated achievement. Van Ek (1976) stated that the elements that need reflection are the type of syllabus that can best facilitate the attainment of the desired outcomes, course objectives that guide the design and execution of the instructional experience, the selection of the most suitable learning activities, and the optimal pedagogical approach for organizing those learning activities.

2. Stages of Syllabus Design

According to Graves (2000, p4), a syllabus can be regarded as a system where the various components are interconnected, and each process influences the others in some way. A syllabus should adhere to specific stages, namely, "assessing needs, formulating goals and objectives, developing materials, designing an assessment plan, organizing the content, and conceptualizing content". These steps should be formulated based on the context and beliefs of the syllabus designers. However, there is no sequential order in the execution of these steps. In the role of a course designer, one may begin at any point within the framework, provided that it is a sensible starting point.

Determining what constitutes a sensible starting point is based upon one's beliefs and comprehension, whether expressed or not, as well as the actuality of the context and one's knowledge of the students. As

Graves (2000, p.17) asserts, determining a clear context is of utmost significance as it assists in establishing the resources and constraints that guide decisions.

2.1. Assessing Needs

The initial phase of constructing a syllabus and a fundamental aspect that should be regarded is the identification of learners' needs and requirements. Richards et al. (1992, pp.242- 243) define NA as a procedure that involves establishing the language needs of learners and organizing those needs in order of priority. Nunan (1988, p.13) also offers a definition of NA that emphasizes the importance of information gathering. Munby (1978) identified the techniques and procedures used to collect syllabus design information as constituting NA.

This stage entails gathering data on the learners' linguistic requirements, preferences, and objectives. This phase employs a number of techniques, such as questionnaires, observations, and interviews. The NA serves as a blueprint for determining the succeeding curriculum decisions. In the ESP course, learners acquire language skills to communicate academic and professional information and perform related functions. They may necessitate English to peruse scientific articles written in English, or they may attend conferences where English is exclusively used.

As Richards (2001, p.63) pointed out, an essential tenet of the ESP approach in language instruction is that the learner's intended purpose for acquiring a language should be the foundational consideration in formulating a course and its corresponding syllabus. Specifying students' target needs is an essential requirement that pertains to the dictates of the target context. Learners' lacks are closely linked to the necessities of the target situation. Their wants and perspectives on learning must also be considered (Hutchinson & Waters, 1987, p. 55). Target needs alone are inadequate and cannot serve as a dependable indicator. Therefore, the learning situation's circumstances, the learners' knowledge, skills, strategies, and motivation for learning carry significant importance.

2.2. Formulating Goals and Objectives

To learn a language, setting goals is a critical aspect of the instructional process. Goals, which are formulated based on a thorough NA, serve to outline the intended outcomes of the course. Specifically, these goals delineate the various language skills that students will be expected to master by the conclusion of the curriculum, including writing, reading, listening and speaking. The establishment of specific and measurable objectives is a crucial aspect of goal-setting (Richards, 2001, p.141). These objectives facilitate the breakdown of goals into discrete steps that can be subject to observation and assessment. Language forms and functions are the central focus of these objectives.

Goals represent the fundamental purpose of a given course, while objectives serve as an articulation of the specific means by which those goals will be attained or fulfilled. In essence, the goals of a course are similar to a destination, whereas the objectives function as the various pathways that guide the course toward that endpoint. The selection of appropriate goals and objectives is contextually dependent and must be tailored to the unique circumstances of each instructional scenario.

Identifying the goals of a course requires investigating the intended outcomes and proficiencies of this course. This can be achieved through an analysis of the needs of the students involved. To meet the goals, it is imperative to establish clear objectives. This process involves posing the question of what is necessary for students to learn or do in order to achieve these purposes. As Nunan (1988, p. 6) posits, objectives are essentially a specific means of formulating or articulating content and tasks. Thus, objectives are intrinsically linked to the content of the course. An essential step in designing a syllabus is determining the goals and breaking them down into objectives. When both the goals and objectives are clearly articulated, it becomes easier for teachers to choose the appropriate content and tasks for each course.

2.3. Conceptualizing Content

After analysing the requirements of the learners, it is imperative to search for appropriate content that accommodates their needs in the form of “the language items, ideas, skills and strategies that meet the goals of the course” (Nation & Macalister, 2010, p. 8). Conceptualizing content, according to Graves (2000, pp.37-38), involves what to learn, what content to include, and how to organize the content to create a relationship among the varied elements of the syllabus. Consequently, the process of selecting content involves carefully choosing topics, themes, and notions that can provide meaningful contexts for meeting the learning objectives and reflect the choices and perspectives of the designer.

It is preferable to use authentic resources that are related to the interests of the students and relate to their background. To achieve the set objectives, it is important to identify the necessary language skills and learning strategies. These include grammatical, sociolinguistic, discourse, and strategic competence. Certain criteria exist that must be considered when selecting the functions of language to be taught. As Kaur (1990, p.10) posits, the objectives serve as a focal point for the subject matter elements, which may include specific structures, sets of functions, or even a range of communicative events. The essential aim of ESP instruction is not limited to providing students with a mere overview of specific topics but also to enhance their linguistic repertoire by introducing technical terminology and vocabulary, in addition to refining their general grammatical and syntactical skills.

Shaw (1975) put forth comprehensive principles for the selection of content, centred on the level of students and the duration of the course. These principles serve as reliable indicators for assessing the difficulty of the course and the scope of knowledge that is to be imparted. Hence, for selecting content, we need to

evaluate the learner's prior knowledge and their current level of understanding, determine the quantity of content to be covered in the course, examine the competencies that learners should acquire, and lastly, assess the coverage of grammatical aspects.

2.4. Developing Material

After the selection of content comes the step of choosing and developing materials and activities. Materials, in the educational context, refer to any resource used to supplement the learning process and facilitate comprehension, such as textbooks, workbooks, and audio-visual aids. The selection of suitable media and materials is a crucial aspect of the teaching process, as the instructional material must be presented to learners in a manner that contributes to facilitating the learning process (Nation & Macalister, 2010, p.9). Furthermore, implementing authentic materials is highly recommended as they are known to present content in an engaging and stimulating manner.

It is essential to note that the choice of materials is flexible and contingent upon the learning environment and objectives at hand (Nation & Macalister, 2010, p.159). For instance, a newspaper article may be used as a tool to cultivate reading proficiency, expand learners' vocabularies, and explore cultural themes. Alternatively, data visualization may be used to help clarify intricate concepts, such as the various body organs or atom components.

The selection of the appropriate material is of significant importance to the course's efficacy. Graves (2000, p.156) mentioned six considerations when developing materials: learners (experience, background, and affective needs), learning objectives, language (grammar, vocabulary), social context, activity/task type, and materials (authentic, print, and audio).

Ellis and Johnson (1994, p.115) explained that the selection of material significantly influences the linguistic exposure that learners receive and, as a result, shapes the fundamental aspects of their educational experience with respect to vocabulary, syntactic structures, and functional language use. According to them, this choice bears implications for the pedagogical methods and techniques employed for the students' acquisition of knowledge. They further argue that the subject matter or thematic content of the materials serves as a crucial element of the instructional package, particularly concerning its motivational aspects and relevance to the learners.

The choice of ESP material is dependent upon the learners' needs with respect to their future occupations. Consequently, the material selected ought to give particular attention to the appropriate selection of topics and include "tasks and activities that practice the target skills area" (Ellis & Johnson, 1994, p.115). An additional factor that deserves consideration is the extent of linguistic competence that students have already acquired and the targeted amount of knowledge that they require to communicate effectively in their respective professions. Since ESP is learner-centred, the selection of material should mirror the students'

considerations. Lewis and Hill (1993, pp.52-53) posit that these considerations comprise a series of inquiries, such as whether the material is beneficial to the students, whether it arouses students' curiosity, whether it is pertinent to the students and their needs, whether the tasks and activities are enjoyable to perform, whether the students consider the tasks and activities valuable, etc...

2.5. Organizing the Course

Lesson planning is a crucial component of the curriculum development process. To ensure that the learning objectives are achieved, lesson plans are created for each unit; these plans encompass various elements. Graves (2000, p.125) explained that organizing a course involves five overlapping processes: (a) determining the organization principle (theme, genre, tasks), (b) identifying units or modules based on the organization principle, (c) sequencing the units, (d) deciding on the language and skills of each unit and (e) organizing the content within each unit.

For the purpose of organizing courses, two approaches may be used: the building approach and the recycling approach. The building approach aligns with the theories of educational psychologists like Piaget (1972), who emphasized the importance of progressively building upon a learner's existing knowledge and skills. Vygotsky's Zone of Proximal Development (ZPD) (1978) reflects the same concept, which suggests that learning is most effective when it builds on what the learner is ready to learn but requires guidance and encouragement from the teacher. The recycling approach aligns with the principles of reinforcement and repetition found in behaviourist theories of learning, where repeated exposure to the same material in different contexts is believed to strengthen learning and memory retention (Bruner, 1960).

The building approach involves progressing from simple to complex ideas and from concrete to abstract concepts. In a writing course, for example, it is advisable to teach students first how to compose a simple paragraph before developing a full essay. On the other hand, the recycling approach involves presenting the same material to students in varying formats or through different activities. For instance, a reading material may be adapted to a dialogue or role-play activity, while a listening activity may be transformed into a writing exercise.

2.6. Designing an Assessment Plan

Evaluation is a continuous process that is implemented regularly to monitor the success of the syllabus. Feedbacks from students and teachers are essential components of this process. Modifications are made based on the feedback received to ensure that the syllabus is continuously improving. To measure the achievement of objectives, both formative (offer constructive feedback to improve students' learning) and summative (concerned with how well students have learned) assessments are developed (Richards, 1990, p17; Surgenor, 2010). Whenever possible, authentic performance-based tasks are used in the assessment process for

heightened accuracy. Evaluation focus may include many aspects, like the quality of the program, its outcomes, content, teaching methods, materials and so on (Richards, 2001, p.278).

Over the course of time, it is imperative that the syllabus possess inherent flexibility, allowing negotiable modifications to accommodate the desired needs. A syllabus that proves effective must embody up-to-date concepts in the fields of psychology, linguistics, sociology, and education in a manner that is consistent with the remaining aspects of the curriculum.

3. Types of Syllabi

According to Jordon (2009, pp.60 -63), the diverse categories of syllabi can be put within three general classifications: (a) Content/Product (emphasizing the outcome), (b) Skills, and (c) Method/Process (highlighting the means to achieve an objective). Under this classification, he further subdivided the first category into notional-functional, situational, topic, and content-based syllabi. The third classification is further divided into process-oriented, procedural/task-based, and learner-centred/negotiated syllabi. These categories of syllabi are not wholly discrete from one another. For instance, the differentiation between task-based and skill-based syllabi tends to be minimal. In such cases, the primary distinguishing element frequently exists in how the instructional content is implemented within the actual pedagogical framework (Reilly, 1988).

Ur (2012, p.76) listed ten types of syllabi: grammatical, lexical, grammatical–lexical: (where both structures and lexis are emphasized), situational (focusing on specific situations like ‘at the hotel’), topic-based (including specific themes like vacation), notional (general notions may include ‘place,’ or ‘colour’), functional–notional (what functions can be performed using language like ‘denying,’ or ‘promising’), mixed or ‘multi-strand’ (integration of various dimensions, delineation of topics, tasks, notions and functions, alongside vocabulary and grammar), procedural (specifying the tasks to be accomplished rather than the linguistic content itself or its meanings, with examples including map-reading, conducting scientific experiments, and story-writing), and finally, process (the sole syllabus that is not predefined, where the course content is collaboratively negotiated with learners at both the beginning and throughout the course, and is ultimately documented retrospectively).

Conclusion

Syllabus design plays a central role in the success of any ESP course. A well-designed syllabus ensures that learning is focused, organised and relevant to students’ needs. It helps both teachers and learners work towards clear and meaningful objectives. There is no single perfect type of syllabus. Teachers often combine different syllabus types to create a balanced and flexible course.